



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: ADOLPHUS PRUITT		PHONE NUMBER: 314-361-8600	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: ST. LOUIS CITY NAACP		TITLE:	
ADDRESS: 4811 DELMAR			
CITY: ST. LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63108
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:	SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM	
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			



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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: ALESHA DIANE SCHERFFIUS		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: anomalisbeing472@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:19 PM
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I support this bill for several reasons. One being I was incarcerated in both Vandalia and Chillicothe from March 2008 to April 2012. While there, I saw how there was no oversight. Chillicothes Major Anders, who needed supervision, told all staff how to pat us down. He specifically told all male staff members to put their hands on the insides of our knees with thumbs up and move their hands up until their thumbs touched our privates, and then they were to graze our private parts to verify we weren't stealing. They were also to make sure they grazed our nipples when searching our top halves. This style of pat-down is illegal. And grazing the body wasn't the only style; some officers jammed their thumbs up into our privates to make us jump. That's just one of many instances of how the guards are let loose to be in charge of people who, even though they are "state property," still have human rights. The Parole board has absolutely no one looking at them and that leaves them to decide everything on a case by case basis. 2 women with the same crime and history can get two different answers for example they could both get a set back but only one could see the board in 2 years where the other might have to wait 4. They make up the rules as they see fit. My second reason for supporting this bill is for friends in all facilities, especially the men's. In JCCC, the Parole Board has gone beyond making up their own rules they are misusing the legal language to serve their purpose. The purpose is most likely is keep all the federal funding coming in for Class A felonies. I know how the system works since I have been in the system, and I was trained to be a Probation and Parole officer before I went to prison. If there is no one to keep things equal on every level of a prison, so people's rights aren't taken away by all the different levels then how do any of these people considered "state property" have any rights as humans? We need someone who acknowledges that the state has control over human Being, NOT Slaves. I am always willing to speak to anyone about my experience while I was incarcerated. I have been a part of several advocacy groups. I have also been to Jeff city to do Lobby Day and spoke with over 50 members of the house and senate and would love to meet and talk with everyone again. I am always available.



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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: ANN SCHMITT		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: joyfulgal2@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 1:37 PM
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I am definitely in favor of those who are incarcerated having the right to vote. I am also in favor of having oversight of jails and prisons. I think locking human beings up like animals is never rehabilitary, and I also think its very easy for someone to abuse a human who is incarcerated.



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WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: ANTON WASHINGTON		PHONE NUMBER: 913-240-4126	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: CREATIVE INNOVATIVE		TITLE: CEO/EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR	
ADDRESS: 7325 TROOST AVE			
CITY: KANSAS CITY		STATE: MO	ZIP: 64131
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:	SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM	
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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: BAHIYA HIBA SHAKUR		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: bhshakur@outlook.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 5:46 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

Dear Members of the House Corrections Committee, please vote YES on HB 774, HB 603, and HB 729. These bills would create independent prison oversight in Missouri. This is important because there is a lot of abuse, neglect, violence, understaffing, and lack of programming inside our state prisons. These poor conditions affect incarcerated people, correctional staff, and the families of both negatively. I encourage you to visit a prison and talk to both incarcerated people and staff, and VOTE YES on HB 774, HB 603, and HB 729. Thank you. A former brother-in-law of mine served more than 20 years. During that time he was beaten mercilessly. Staff said inmates beat him. Inmates said staff beat him. His Mother worked for several years to get her invalid son home so that she could nurse him back to health. After being released his Mother was able to nurse him for a few years. She died the year after he did. In 2024 I sat in on Zoom calls and heard Mother after Mother crying because her son had been beaten to Death. It's still happening!!!! I have personally been in a facility where 3 women died in December, right before Christmas. And this was in a medical facility. Families fight for years to get their loved one home so that they can care for them. It would save families heartache and save the taxpayers millions of dollars! It's almost summer. 50% of Missouri's prisons still don't have air conditioning. Can you imagine what it is like to be in a small concrete cell with other people and the temperature is over 100 degrees. It's INHUMANE. IT IS UNGODLY!!! STUDY THE NORWEGIAN PRISON SYSTEMS! THEY STUDIED OURS, FOUND THEY DIDN'T WORK AND THEY CHANGED THEIR SYSTEMS!!! THE UNITED STATES OF AMERICA IS BETTER THAN THE DANGEROUSLY DRACONIAN SYSTEMS WE INSIST ON PERPETUATING!!!



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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: BARBARA K CARLETON		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: bkcarleton63@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 10:41 PM
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As a mother of a first time offender it has been an eye opening experience dealing with doc. Information is not as accessible as they claim it to be and follow through may only happen with persistence on my part and even then it is limited. This could be anything from what is considered acceptable visiting attire to what is eligible to bring in for a food visit depending on who is running the visiting area. Recently my son had a medical emergency that was near fatal. The camp did not make me aware of the seriousness of the situation. I only found out he was not at the facility 6 days after he was taken to the hospital because I was calling about visiting. I am not sure if they would have even told me until he died which his doctor said he was near death. No family should have to go through the agony of the uncertainty I went through for 2 weeks. Once he was discharged from the public hospital to a tcu in doc was I able to get any information which took 5 days and multiple phone calls.



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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: BRENDA CAMPBELL AND STANLEY CAMPBELL		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: campbellbk45@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 10:42 AM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

Dear Members of the House Corrections Committee, please vote YES on HB603, HB729, and HB774. These Bills would create independent prison oversight in Missouri. These are important because there is a lot of abuse, neglect, violence, understaffing, and lack of programming inside our state prisons. This creates negative conditions for incarcerated persons, correctional staff, and the families of both. For instance, aware of what we consider medical negligence wherein an incarcerated person, while dealing with 50% vision loss on the right side of both eyes, was denied ADA accommodations at one of the prisons. At that prison, the ADA Coordinator lied to us that the incarcerated person said she/he could see fine even though the medical file contradicted this. This is just one of many examples we have experienced. We encourage you to visit a Missouri prison and talk to both incarcerated persons and staff regarding the conditions within the prisons. PLEASE VOTE YES on Hwe are personally B603, HB729, and HB774. Thank you for your consideration of these comments.



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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: BRICE WOODCOCK		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: bricewoodcock@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 3:29 PM

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Accountability measures are needed to address systemic health and safety conditions in Missouri's prisons.



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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: CHERE BURTONHARTZELL		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: chere.burtonhartzell.cbh@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 2:38 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

04/02/2025 @ 9:26 a.m.To Whom It Concerns:My name is Chere BurtonHartzell, I'm a concerned mother of an inmate at one of these prisons in Missouri. I am aware of everything at goes on at these prisons and the prisoners. These prisons are not fit for anyone to live in them, they are over crowded, black mold in them, abusive to the prisoners and the C.Os.. I support these following House Bills, HB 790, HB 874, HB 603, HB 774, HB 729. These bills are to improve and make the Department of Corrections take responsibility of their actions. These bills will also give the inmates the right to vote after they get out of prison.



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WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: CLIFFTON DAVIS		PHONE NUMBER: 573-590-1107	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: MISSOURI JUSTICE COALITION		TITLE: ORGANIZER	
ADDRESS: 1512 BUSINESS 70 W			
CITY: COLUMBIA		STATE: MO	ZIP: 65203
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:	SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM	
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WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: CLIFTON DAVIS		PHONE NUMBER: 573-590-1107	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: MOJUSTICE		TITLE: ACTIVISTS	
ADDRESS: 4608 DERBY RIDGE DR			
CITY: COLUMBIA		STATE: MO	ZIP: 65202
EMAIL: cliftonx19@yahoo.com	ATTENDANCE: In-Person		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 4:20 AM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

Statement in Support of HB 774/HB 603 and HB 729: The Missouri State Corrections Ombudsperson ActAs concerned citizens, we must ensure that our criminal justice system operates with transparency, accountability, and fairness. HB 774, HB 603, and HB 729 represent a critical step forward in protecting the rights, safety, and dignity of both incarcerated individuals and correctional staff within Missouri's prison system. For too long, reports of abuse, neglect, unsafe conditions, and lack of oversight have plagued our correctional facilities. The creation of an independent State Corrections Ombudsperson is not only a necessary reform—it is a moral obligation. This bill will establish an independent body with the authority to inspect prisons, investigate complaints, and ensure accountability without fear of retaliation. Furthermore, the Corrections Oversight Committee will ensure that this new office remains independent, nonpartisan, and focused on meaningful reforms. By including lawmakers, former correctional staff, medical professionals, prisoner advocacy groups, and formerly incarcerated individuals, this committee will ensure that all voices are heard in the pursuit of a more just and effective corrections system. Transparency breeds trust and change. By implementing regular inspections, requiring corrective action plans, and making reports publicly available, this bill shines a light on the conditions behind prison walls, ensuring that Missouri's correctional facilities meet basic human rights standards. Beyond accountability, HB 774/HB 603 and HB 729 are smart policy. Improving prison conditions reduces violence, promotes rehabilitation, and enhances public safety by preparing individuals for successful reintegration into society. Supporting this legislation is not just about improving prisons—it is about investing in safer communities for all Missourians. We urge our legislators to stand on the right side of history and pass HB 774, HB 603, and HB 729. By doing so, Missouri will take a bold step toward a fair, humane, and accountable criminal justice system. Respectfully submitted, Clifton Davis MOJUSTICE 04/02/2025



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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: COURTNEY CURTIS		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM
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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: CRYSTAL VANCE		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: wizardcl@yahoo.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 12:22 PM
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I have or several friends and or family housed in Missouri DOC. I agree that oversight. Is a must for those locked up and as well as those that work in the DOC. I've had to call medical and case workers several times before the inmates in need got any actions brought to attention.



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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: CYNTHIA KIMMEL		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: kimmel_cindy@yahoo.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 1:55 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

My son died in Missouri prison may 17- 22 I'm still waiting for answer s neither I or my lawyer could get the sunshine requests even though we tried repeatedly I recently found out a correction officer has been charged for bringing in the drugs that killed him something has to change as a parent we seem to have no rights when something happens to our loved ones



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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: CYNTHIA KIMMEL		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: kimmel_cindy@yahoo.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 11:12 AM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

My son died in prison secc Charleston Mo may 17,2022 me and my lawyer tried getting his sunshine requests still haven't got it took a year and half to get his autopsy report parents seem to have no rights when something happens to their family in the department of corrections that's not right I recently found out a correctional officer has been charged for bringing in the drugs that killed my son



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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: DALISHA WALLET		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: coldwater179@outlook.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 4:31 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

Hello, HB729 is a must! There is no accountability for Missouri Department of Corrections. It's known to many of us as "The New Slavery" I've personally had the displeasure of experiencing the sick and twisted ways of DOC. Examples:FRDC Has kept my son in the hole since he arrived November 20,2024. They wrote him up for having damaged shoes, despite that he received them in that condition, he was written up for singing and talking. Justin Turner refused to respond to our emails regarding these problems. And every avenue we took to investigate, DOC on all levels blocked us. They refused to release my son's records despite his verbal and written consent. It took for me to cc in Rep Collins to get a response from a warden, who was full of angriness. He told me to "stop emailing mycase workers and if you want his records and write ups get a lawyer, and even then you still won't get it! Animalistic is what you call that.



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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: DEB WATSON		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: debwatson59@icloud.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 3/31/2025 12:58 PM
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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: DEB WATSON		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: debwatson59@icloud.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 11:17 AM
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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: DENA NOTZ		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: cccforchange24@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 3/27/2025 8:03 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

Greetings, I would like to submit my testimony in support of an independent oversight committee for the Missouri Department of Corrections. It has become abundantly clear that they are not able to oversee themselves, nor should they be. Loved ones and prison residents deserve to see accountability and transparency when it comes to their concerns and complaints. The Missouri Department of Corrections has promised to keep those under their care safe and secure. The prison residents will tell you they feel anything but safe and secure. As a former employee of the Missouri Department of Corrections, nothing I saw during my employment seemed like safety or security was a priority for staff or inmates. I wholeheartedly support this bill. Missouri needs this! Thank you for allowing me to testify.



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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: ELOISE ROWAN		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: eloiserowan.1@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 2:03 PM

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These correctional facilities need to be investigated and closed. There were times when I was told that they have no soap to purchase, no detergent for cleaning clothes, facility in the kitchen etc.



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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: ERICA WILLIAMS		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM
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WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: HANNAH ADAMS		PHONE NUMBER: 417-456-2714	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: MISSOURI PRISON REFORM		TITLE: COMMUNICATIONS ORGANIZER	
ADDRESS: 1820 S MINNESOTA AVE			
CITY: JOPLIN		STATE: MO	ZIP: 64804
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:	SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM	
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WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: HEATHER WALLIN		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: wallinhe@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 10:42 AM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

Dear Members of the House Corrections Committee, please vote YES on HB 774, HB 603, and HB 729. These bills would create independent prison oversight in Missouri. This is important because there is a lot of abuse, neglect, violence, understaffing, and lack of programming inside our state prisons. These poor conditions affect incarcerated people, correctional staff, and the families of both negatively. I encourage you to visit a prison and talk to both incarcerated people and staff, and VOTE YES on HB 774, HB 603, and HB 729. Thank you



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WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: JAMES FIGUEROA-ROBNETT JR.		PHONE NUMBER: 573-356-4433	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: NATIONAL ASSOCIATION FOR THE ADVANCEMENT OF COLORED PEOPLE,		TITLE: VICE CHAIR PRISONER PROJECT ASSISTANCE COMMITTEE	
ADDRESS: 111 WEST HIGH			
CITY: JEFFERSON CITY		STATE: MO	ZIP: 65101
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:	SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM	
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MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: JANIS MENSAH		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: janis.mensah@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 1:36 PM

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I was chair of the jail oversight board for st louis city. we were able to bring a lot more public attention to and engagement with the horrible jail conditions and deaths. Public oversight is essential as long as jails and prisons exist.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
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BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: JEANETTE MOTT OXFORD		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: jmo.mott.oxford@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 7:39 PM
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Chairman Mayhew and Members of the House Committee on Corrections and Public Institutions, I ask that you vote DO PASS on HB 729. I am part of the Prison Ministry Team at Epiphany United Church of Christ, and I am aware of inadequate health care sometimes given in DOC facilities. I believe better nutrition should be provided to prisoners and that health care costs would be reduced if we offered heart healthy meals. A man that I visit at Farmington supplements the prison meals with high-salt and high-fat foods he can purchase in the commissary because he leaves the chow hall hungry. There are certainly many other issues that need to be addressed including bullying of prisoners with disabilities. My thanks to Rep. Collins for this legislation.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
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BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
REGISTERED LOBBYIST:			
WITNESS NAME: JEFF SMITH		PHONE NUMBER: 314-323-0915	
REPRESENTING: MISSOURI APPLESEED		TITLE:	
ADDRESS: 5380 MAGNOLIA AVE.			
CITY: ST. LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63139
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:	SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM	
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BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: JERIKA WHITE		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: EMPOWER MISSOURI		TITLE: CRIMINAL JUSTICE POLICY MANAGER	
ADDRESS:			
CITY: ST. LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63033
EMAIL: jerika@empowermissouri.org	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 4:09 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

Date: April 2, 2025 To: Chairman Mayhew and Members, Corrections and Public Institutions Committee From: Jerika White, Criminal Justice Policy Manager, Empower Missouri RE: Support HB 774, 603, 729 As the largest and oldest anti-poverty non-profit in our state, Empower Missouri is committed to improving the quality of life for all Missouri residents through advocacy. Since its inception, Empower Missouri has prioritized addressing the criminal justice system and its impacts, advocating for stronger Department of Corrections (DOC) oversight and a more effective accountability system. I am testifying on behalf of Empower Missouri to support HB 774 by Rep. Bill Allen, HB 603 by Rep. Bill Lucas, and HB 729 by Rep. Kim Collins. These bills would establish an Office of State Ombudsman within the Department of Corrections. The Office will provide information to those who are incarcerated, monitor prison conditions for the purpose of helping to ensure the adequacy of care received by those who are incarcerated, improve the quality of life experienced by them, and establish a state-wide reporting system to collect data. These bills will also increase transparency and accountability in the Missouri state prison system and help all those impacted by this system. It is important to have external accountability for any institution that is tasked with providing services for the public. The correctional department provides the day-to-day needs of people who are incarcerated however we do not have the accountability foundation. An independent oversight system is necessary to help root out the abuse and overall corruption that occurs within the prison system. Most importantly, it is there to protect the well-being of all those who live and work inside of state prisons. This is a definite need, especially in our state, as Missouri prisons have a long legacy of abuse, harassment, and medical negligence, coupled with a pattern of misinformation regarding deaths in custody. In Missouri, there are well over 23,000 residents living in the 19+ facilities across the state. Severe staffing shortages in recent years have made existing problems more frequent, and the number of in-custody deaths hit a record high in 2024 with 139 deaths total. Othel Moore Jr.'s family made his final cries for help publicly viewable by releasing the footage of his murder, and it was gut-wrenching to watch the overall neglect and actions of the DOC. Many more are experiencing similar conditions, and both residents and workers are at risk of being victimized by failures within the system. The Missouri Department of Corrections has an 830 million dollar budget in 2025. To date, Missouri has paid over \$75 million in lawsuit settlements and verdicts since 2020. These costs are being borne by MO taxpayers and residents. Our research found that the range of settlements varied from hostile work environments, numerous sexual assaults, employee discrimination, and overall poor conditions within the facilities. Both past department employees and formerly incarcerated individuals have sought lawsuits against the state for these reasons. In the fiscal note it states that the general revenue will be over \$500,000. The DOC is already spending more than that with the ongoing lawsuits and monthly

expenses within the facilities. As taxpayers, it is important to know where our tax dollars are being spent. Many Missouri residents and families of both correctional workers and residents are left in the unknown about what occurs within the DOC facilities. In conclusion, having independent oversight will provide the transparency necessary to move forward. Oversight alone will not fix the entrenched issues, but it will provide steps towards creating the accountability system necessary for residents within the facilities, correctional staff, their families, and the community. For these reasons, I encourage the committee to support and vote Yes on HB 774, 603 and 729.



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BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: JOANNE HAGLOF		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: jhh816719@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 11:01 AM
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Dear Members of the House Corrections Committee, please vote YES on HB 774, HB 603, and HB 729. These bills would create independent prison oversight in Missouri. This is important because there is a lot of abuse, neglect, violence, understaffing, and lack of programming inside our state prisons. These poor conditions affect incarcerated people, correctional staff, and the families of both negatively. I encourage you to visit a prison and talk to both incarcerated people and staff, and VOTE YES on HB 774, HB 603, and HB 729. Thank you.



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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: JOHN A GANDY		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: gandyj@sbcglobal.net	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 4:42 PM

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I believe those who are on probation or parole should be afforded the opportunity to participate in our political system especially the eligibility to vote.



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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: JOHN BOWMAN		PHONE NUMBER: 314-322-4441	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: NAACP ST LOUIS COUNTY		TITLE: PRESIDENT	
ADDRESS: 4201 MINOMA LN			
CITY: SAINT LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63121
EMAIL: jbowman@naacpstlouiscounty.org	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 7:58 PM

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This will help protect and provide oversight for incarcerated people.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: JUDY DIANE POPE		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: otwomiata@yahoo.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 2:07 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

Thank you for bringing this house bill to be voted on. I visit Modoc twice monthly and witness the unfair treatment of visitors having to be scanned while staff are ignored. The inhumane treatment of food service feeding the residents with food labels that read .. not for human consumption. The phone service we pay fo is always filled with static . A conversation can't be held . Belongings aren't transported when a resident leaves for another camp. Medical is non existent to those needing it. Wrong meds are being given. Drug test aren't given to staff. Residence are being accused of being under the influence when they're sick or just waking up from sleep. Affairs among staff with residence are widespread. I've witnessed a female correctional officer from an institution visiting an inmate at another institution. Nepotism is strong among each facility. Wardens & correctional officers are being fired but never charged for allowing drugs & deaths in every facility of doc. We need oversight!! Older residents who can barely walk should be released to help with overcrowding. The poor is being picked on and the residents who have money on their books and cause zero problems are being denied outdates so the doc can keep making money off their families. When a family member calls a residents C.O. to advocate for them, the CO often denies meeting with the resident for purpose of retaliation. We need reform now. Resident's are dropping dead due to drugs getting in. Lower levels need rehab away from the higher levels. We need to clean up our DOC & Probation & Parole in. Missouri. Thank you for everything you're to get these correctional house bills passed



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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: KAREN BACKUES KEIL		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM
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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: KAREN FOWLER		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: paydenn0306@yahoo.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 1:41 PM
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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: KAREN HEITKAMP		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: thewaxprincess@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 5:01 PM
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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: KATHRYN PARISH		PHONE NUMBER: 314-277-7670	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: MISSOURI ASSOCIATION OF CRIMINAL DEFENSE ATTORNEYS		TITLE: BOARD MEMBER, MISSOURI ASSOCIATION OF CRIMINAL DEF	
ADDRESS: 3407 JEFFERSON, #128			
CITY: SAINT LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63118
EMAIL: kay@carlyleparishlaw.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 9:29 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

Dear Chair Mayhew and Committee Members: I regret that I could not be present to testify today, but wanted to express my and the Missouri Association of Criminal Defense Lawyers' support for increased DO Oversight. I do a lot of work with clients in the state's jails and prisons and it seems like every other week, I am hearing different stories of lack of health care, abuse, and other issues. I often find myself concerned for the health and safety of my clients. I appreciate the attention that Reps. Collins, Lucas, and Allen are bringing to the issue and their efforts to implement reforms. I have been following Rep. Collins' work closely particularly in this regard, and am so heartened to see a legislator giving this issue and the people we house in our prisons, who are in reality some of the most vulnerable people in our society, the care and concern that is merited. I am happy to consult on any particular aspects of the various proposals or speak more to any member of the committee individually about my experiences and the experiences of my clients. I hope that this Committee will take seriously the need for increased oversight of our corrections institutions.



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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: KEARA WRIGHT		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: kearabwright@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 7:02 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

Dear Members of the Missouri House of Representatives, I am writing to express my strong support for House Bill 729, which seeks to establish the Office of the Department of Corrections Ombudsman. This initiative is crucial to ensure that our state's correctional facilities operate safely and effectively, upholding the principles of accountability and transparency that are fundamental to our justice system. Recent data underscores the urgent need for enhanced oversight within Missouri's prison system. In 2024, preliminary figures indicate that 139 individuals died while in custody—the highest number on record and a continuation of a troubling trend averaging over 10 deaths per month over the past five years. While many of these deaths have been declared due to health reasons, the limited scope of autopsy classification undermines the lack of adequate and timely medical care provided to inmates. With proper oversight, both minor and severe health conditions can be treated in a timely matter and prevent unnecessary fatalities. Moreover, the rise in drug-related incidents within correctional facilities is alarming. Reports indicate that drug overdoses, particularly involving fentanyl, have become an increasing cause of death among inmates. For example, in 2023, eight fentanyl overdose deaths occurred at the South Central Correctional Center in Licking, Missouri. This highlights significant issues related to contraband control and the need for comprehensive strategies to address substance abuse within prisons. The financial implications of inadequate oversight are also substantial. Since 2020, Missouri has expended approximately \$70 million in settlements across 139 lawsuits related to the Department of Corrections. Notably, this includes a \$100 million settlement for correctional officers' unpaid work time claims. Such expenditures underscore the potential cost savings that proactive oversight and early intervention could achieve by addressing systemic issues before they escalate into costly legal battles. Establishing the Office of the Department of Corrections Ombudsman will provide an independent body dedicated to monitoring, regulating, and evaluating our correctional facilities. This office will be instrumental in ensuring that prisons adhere to legal and ethical standards, improve treatment and living conditions for one of our most vulnerable populations, investigate staff conduct, and oversee budgetary operations. By supporting House Bill 729, we take a significant step toward fostering a correctional system that embodies empathy, integrity, and fiscal responsibility. Thank you for considering this vital legislation. Sincerely, Keara



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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: KEITH DEN HOLLANDER		PHONE NUMBER: 202-853-0707	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: CHRISTIAN COALITION		TITLE: NATIONAL FIELD DIRECTOR	
ADDRESS: PO BOX 37030			
CITY: WASHINGTON		STATE: DC	ZIP: 20013
EMAIL: Keith@cc.org	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 6:23 PM
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The Christian Coalition is in support of this bill.			



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WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: KEITH ROSE		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: NATIONAL LAWYERS GUILD - ST. LOUIS		TITLE: TREASURER	
ADDRESS: 3428 HUMPHREY ST			
CITY: ST. LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63118
EMAIL: keith@growjustice.org	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 6:41 PM

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The National Lawyers Guild - St. Louis Chapter, and our members, fully supports HB 729, which seeks to uphold the Constitution's prohibition on cruel and unusual punishment, by creating an ombudsman to provide oversight of Missouri's Department of Corrections. The National Lawyers Guild applauds the sponsor of HB 729, Representative Kimberly-Ann Collins of St. Louis City, for her work on this issue, as well as her years of unyielding, compassionate dedication to protecting the Constitutional and Human Rights of all individuals held in Missouri's prison system. However, prison oversight cannot be relegated to a single member of Missouri's Legislature. The people living and working within Missouri's Department of Corrections need a full-time, fully-funded ombudsman.



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WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: KHANIKA HARPER		PHONE NUMBER: 314-530-8331	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: JUSTICE FOR ALL		TITLE: EXECUTIVE DIRECTOR	
ADDRESS:			
CITY: ST. LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63147
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:	SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM	
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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: KIMBERLY WALLIS		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: kimberly.t.wallis@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 3/31/2025 12:22 PM
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This bill would strengthen the oversight and accountability for Missouri's prisons. It is our duty and responsibility to ensure the health and safety of those that our justice system has put into prison. Our goal is justice - not torture or neglect. Our goal is the eventual successful re-introduction of people back into our society.



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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: LAURA BIRDSONG		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM
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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: LINDA KRAM		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: lindakram@charter.net		ATTENDANCE: Written	SUBMIT DATE: 3/31/2025 2:13 PM
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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: LISA STRADER		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: lisa.shafter@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 3/31/2025 12:23 PM

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More oversight will ensure that everyone's rights are being upheld.



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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: LUCAS CALDWELL-MCMILLAN		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: EMPOWER MISSOURI		TITLE: CHIEF OF POLICY	
ADDRESS: 3407 S JEFFERSON #105			
CITY: ST LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63118
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:	SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM	
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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: MARGARET HERMES		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: hermes.margaret@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 2:16 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

Please vote for the passage of House Bill 729. An Ombudsman's office for the Department of Corrections is very much needed. I am aware of abusive treatment suffered by a young man who was incarcerated and had no recourse. We must do better. The incarcerated are paying their debt to society, and we have a debt to them as well. Our prisons are not designed to transform prisoners for the better. Several people I know wrote letters of support for an inmate who was up for parole and mailed them to the parole board. We all received replies thanking us for contributing valuable information and assuring us that our words would be taken into consideration at his hearing. One of us was able to be present at the hearing and engaged in a conversation with one of the parole board members who told her that no letters regarding the inmate had been distributed. I'd like to think that this – a relatively minor travesty in this prisoner's experience in our state's correctional facilities – is one of many atrocities that a team of ombudsmen could address or – much better – prevent.



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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: MARIA GOELLNER		PHONE NUMBER: 717-945-9089	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: FAMM		TITLE: SENIOR DIRECTOR OF STATE POLICY	
ADDRESS: P.O. BOX 11			
CITY: ERIE		STATE: PA	ZIP: 16512
EMAIL: mgoellner@famm.org	ATTENDANCE: Written	SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 1:12 PM	
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

Thank you to Chair Mayhew, Vice Chair Cook, Ranking Minority Member Collins, and members of the Committee for considering this written statement in support of HB 774 by Rep. Bill Allen (R-17), HB 603 by Rep. Bill Lucas (R-115), and HB 729 by Rep. Kim Collins (D-77). FAMM is a nonpartisan, nonprofit organization that advocates sentencing and prison policies that are individualized, fair, protect public safety, and preserve families. The Conservative Political Action Committee (CPAC), the Christian Coalition, current and former correctional officers, FAMM, and many others support this policy. It would increase transparency and accountability in the Missouri state prison system by establishing an independent corrections ombudsperson's office and a corrections oversight committee with power to receive and investigate complaints, inspect prisons, and recommend improvements. This legislation will benefit Missouri correctional staff, incarcerated people, and families of both. The Missouri Department of Corrections (MDOC) is a very large agency with an \$830 million dollar 2025 budget. By their nature, prisons are closed environments. It is difficult for the taxpaying public, let alone impacted families, to understand what happens behind the walls. Yet MDOC employs over 10,000 people, incarcerates 23,000, and affects an untold number through the ripple impact on the families of those who live and work in its 19+ facilities. FAMM routinely gets reports of violence, abuse, neglect, understaffing, and lack of programming from correctional staff and incarcerated people. These reports cut through racial and geographic lines and emanate from the whole state. In fact, Missouri has paid over \$66 million in lawsuit settlements and verdicts in the last four years alone, according to a study by Empower Missouri. Families and taxpayers deserve transparency and accountability from this huge agency. This legislation is a way for the legislature and public to say "show me." Missouri has a good roadmap for oversight legislation. In response to dire conditions in the federal Bureau of Prisons (BOP), United States Congress passed the Federal Prison Oversight Act by 392-2 in the House of Representatives and by unanimous consent in the Senate. It became law in 2024. The bill was sponsored by Sen. Jon Ossoff and Rep. Lucy McBath with co-sponsors Sen. Mike Braun (R-Indiana) and Rep. Kelly Armstrong (R - North Dakota At Large). Every member of the Missouri Congressional Delegation voted for this oversight law. It was supported by correctional staff, the Conservative Political Action Conference (CPAC), Faith and Freedom Coalition, the National District Attorneys Association, and more. The Federal Prison Oversight Act contained two main provisions. First, it allows an independent Inspector General to conduct comprehensive, risk-based inspections of facilities. Second, it allows targeted investigations by the ombudsperson. These features are contained in this legislation. Americans understand the value of increased transparency and accountability in prisons. In a national poll, 82 percent of Americans agreed that every prison system should have independent oversight. Oversight can prevent expensive lawsuits and settlements paid for by

taxpayers. It would also help lawmakers assess MDOC's budget and other needs more accurately. An independent ombudsperson could provide intelligence for the legislature, presenting unbiased, reliable, and accurate reports on the state of facilities and repairs, staffing needs, programming and food shortages, security risks, and dangerous conditions for staff and incarcerated people. This information could inform and guide lawmaker choices about how to improve MDOC and ensure that it operates on a sound and sensible budget. Lawmakers need this steady feedback and insight to appropriately fund a large agency that is often opaque, in part because it is spread all over the state through thousands of employees. Independent oversight benefits everyone it touches. Corrections staff deserve a safe, healthy work environment and need a place to go with complaints that, for whatever reason, are squashed, unanswered, or ignored by the administration. Incarcerated people have a constitutional right to a safe, healthy, humane prison environment and need a place to go when the prison grievance process breaks down or they have no safe place to turn to for help. Families of incarcerated people need someone to call when they cannot get help for their loved one despite following all the rules. Oversight encourages increased professionalism at every level of an agency and has proven successful in several states, e.g. Indiana and Nebraska. FAMM is happy to provide technical assistance and facilitate connections to ombudspeople in other states. We also encourage you to visit a state prison and talk to correctional staff and incarcerated people. Please reach out to mcharles@famm.org and mgoellner@famm.org or (717) 945-9089 for more information or to discuss this matter further. Citations available upon request.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: MARIA LINDBERGH		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: mariaddonnici@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 9:43 AM

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There is a need for accountability measures to address systemic health and safety measures in Missouri's prisons.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: MARIE CATHERINE MILLER		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: grandmarockks1969@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 6:45 PM
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My Name is Marie Miller, I have 2 Sons in Moberly. my son Matthew has 11 yrs in . 6 yrs write up free, He has completed ITC program has been involved in Launch code also worked the Metal plant and is in the Art program also involved in Prid program. Guards see him every day. On 12/10/25 guard placed my son in a cell with his back to cell mate while they took off his cuffs, before he could turn around the cell mate bashed my sons face off metal bed, he got stitches and maced ASST Warden/ FUM Rash Lied to me said she seen my son and he didn't have stitches, When Medical called me they told me about my sons stitches, Now being retaliated against because I keep reaching out for Help, When Matthew was being attacked my other son yelled for Sargent and they put him in a cell with nothing but boxers, Guards watched him suffer coldest day on Camera Co asked to help my son and higher up denied help. Cruel and inhuman treatment My sons Actions show their true self, My Son was attacked by a guard in Licking and they covered up and tortured them in the hole for a year,, I'm emotionally and Mentally Drained Watching the abuse of Power, Please Everyday there's another Family getting a call. Thank you for your time, LORD HEAR OUR PRAYERS



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: MATTHEW CHARLES		PHONE NUMBER: 573-616-9860	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: FAMM		TITLE:	
ADDRESS: 1100 H STREET NW			
CITY: WASHINGTON		STATE: DC	ZIP: 20005
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:	SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM	
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: MELISSA WRIGHT		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: mamwright@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 3/31/2025 11:40 AM

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Accountability measures are needed to address systemic health and safety conditions in Missouri's prisons.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: MICHAEL DREYER		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: mdreyer93@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 10:45 PM

THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.

I support oversight for Missouri Department of Corrections – accountability measures are needed to address systemic health and safety conditions in Missouri’s prisons.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: ML SMITH		PHONE NUMBER: 314-301-9520	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: MISSOURI JUSTICE COALITION		TITLE: FOUNDER/DIRECTOR	
ADDRESS: PO BOX 300563			
CITY: ST. LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63130
EMAIL: mojusticecoalition@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 10:26 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

In seven of the previous eight years, more than 100 individuals have died in the custody of the Missouri DOC. This is in spite of the fact that Missouri prisons hold one third less people today than they did a decade or more ago. The reason why in-custody deaths have increased so drastically is because there has not been any type of independent oversight, investigations, or accountability focused on the myriad issues inside of these prisons, so the problems have festered and over time become more dire. In 2024, 139 individuals lost their lives while in custody of the MoDOC. There has been only one case where criminal charges have been brought - that of Mr. Othel Moore Jr who was killed by staff on Dec. 8, 2023 at the JCCC facility. Any institution that wields power over others should not be able to investigate itself and hold itself above accountability. Mr. Moore's case is not the only one that deserves consequences. The more than 100 in-custody deaths per year need to be investigated. Although people are incarcerated, that does not mean they lose their humanity and that should not mean they lose their lives. I support these bills because oversight of the MoDOC is needed and necessary.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
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BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: NAOMI KELLY-BATES		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: naomikelly@sbcglobal.net	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 4:56 PM

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Help provide more transparency abd oversight of the correctional system so inmates are safe in their environment.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
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BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: NICOLE BARROWS		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: NIMROD CHAPEL JR.		PHONE NUMBER: 816-309-5009	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: MISSOURI NAACP		TITLE: PRESIDENT	
ADDRESS: 111 W HIGH ST			
CITY: JEFFERSON CITY		STATE: MO	ZIP: 65101
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:	SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM	
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: ORVILLE MCDONALD		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: PASTOR RICHARD JACKSON		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: audimanasseh@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 9:52 AM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

Good morning! strongly support HB 729-Collins. As a returning citizen, I know first hand the abuse allowed in the Department of Corrections. I have witness, physical abuse my some correctional officer, with the full understanding, their brother, sister or cousin is the Captain and so the report will not favor the incarcerated person. Any person, providing services to anyone, needs to be held accountable, with out options or discussions especially, in Missouri Department of Corrections. I support every phrase of this bill because people lives are at sake. Women are being sexually assaulted and it received as another bad cup of coffee. These confined citizens, are human beings and need to be treated as such knowing there is legal back-up and the accountability team, willing, ready and able to take all necessary actions to eliminate any abuse. That's my voice and I thank you for your eyes.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
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BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: PATRICK D. PURTILL		PHONE NUMBER: 757-903-5224	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: UNIFY.US		TITLE: EXECUTIVE VICE PRESIDENT & GENERAL COUNSEL	
ADDRESS: 402A SOUTH CAPITOL STREET SE			
CITY: WASHINGTON		STATE: DC	ZIP: 20003
EMAIL: ppurtill@unifyus.us	ATTENDANCE: Written	SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 10:19 AM	
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

On behalf of Unify.US, I am writing in support of the three prison oversight bills currently before the Corrections and Public Institutions Committee (HB 603, HB 729, and HB 774), all of which would establish an "Office of the Department of Corrections Ombudsman" and include provisions relating to oversight of the Missouri Department of Corrections. Unify.US is a new addition to the public policy community and is engaged in work across the country to strengthen our economy, our families, and our communities. A merger of economic and faith driven conservatives, we were formed by former principals of the American Conservative Union (better known as "CPAC") and the Faith & Freedom Coalition. The founders of Unify.US have more than 50 years of collective experience as grass roots activists and a significant record on criminal justice policy. Unify.US' President, Timothy Head, was one of the key staffers in the Texas legislature that developed the Justice Reinvestment Initiative, a policy framework that changed the way conservatives have dealt with crime, punishment, and incarceration in 33 states across the country. Our Chief Operating Officer, David Safavian, was formerly the long-time general counsel and executive vice president at CPAC. He served in the George W. Bush White House and as a chief of staff for a Republican Member of Congress from Utah who was senior on the House Judiciary Committee. For the past ten years I was Director of Legislative Affairs for the Faith & Freedom Coalition where I worked with the first Trump Administration to craft and pass the First Step Act to reduce criminal recidivism and promote public safety. Prior to that I spent three years as Special Assistant to the U.S. Deputy Attorney General where I managed drafting and implementation of regulatory reforms and pilot grant programs and served on the Attorney General's Prisoner Reentry Working Group, the President's Prisoner Reentry Initiative Group, and the Strategic Management Council's Subcommittee on Violent Crime and Gangs. Given our backgrounds, we want to recommend passage of HB 603, HB 729 and/or HB774 because any of these bills would provide greater oversight and accountability in the state's prison system. Last year, we worked at the federal level on similar legislation covering the U.S. Bureau of Prisons that passed with overwhelming bipartisan support (including every member of the Missouri Congressional delegation) and became federal law last July. We believe legislation of this type is important for three reasons. First, greater transparency and oversight would, in our opinion, improve safety for both prisoners and Missouri Department of Corrections (MODOC) staff. In this regard, the challenge before you and your fellow policymakers is significant. Our organizations fully appreciate that there is no "silver bullet" for improving the dangerous climate in which these individuals are housed or work. But we believe this approach is a step in the right direction and will also help with the retention of correctional officers who are under enormous pressure and prone to attrition at high rates. Second, as safety increases in a prison, the MODOC is better positioned to advance pro-social, rehabilitative programming for those inmates open

to amending their lives. It also makes it easier to utilize volunteer and community resources to advance these goals. All of this is directed toward improving public safety in the long run by reducing the recidivism rate of inmates returning to our communities. We are not naïve enough to believe that you can eliminate recidivism altogether, but even small decreases can have an outsized impact on public safety. Third, taking steps to improve transparency and accountability is the best way to prevent the federal courts from stepping in and mandating actions that may end up being harmful. A smart approach now will help Missouri avoid what happened in California where a federal judge ordered a mass release of prisoners to address that system's overcrowding and violence. Preemptively adopting a prison oversight bill is a responsible mechanism to help prevent that type of intervention and release in the future. This balanced approach is designed to provide much-needed oversight and accountability that will help improve conditions for incarcerated individuals and staff alike and position the MODOC to better advance rehabilitation and public safety in the face of federal intervention. We also believe the office of corrections ombudsman would be a great help to the Committee in its oversight role. We urge you to favorably report HB603, HB 729 and/or HB 774. We believe Missouri will benefit from taking this proactive and proven step. If you have any questions or if there is anything that Unify.US can do to support you in this effort, please do not hesitate to contact me at ppurtill@unifyus.us.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: PAUL LOIDA		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: paul.loida@bayer.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 11:44 AM

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Missouri Legislature, I am in support of HB 729: House Bill 729 establishes an "Office of the Department of Corrections Ombudsman" which refers to the monitoring, regulation, and evaluation of correctional facilities (such as prisons) to ensure they operate fairly, safely, and effectively. Oversight can involve:

- Accountability & Transparency – Ensuring prisons follow laws, policies, and ethical standards.
- Conditions & Treatment – Monitoring inmate treatment, healthcare, and living conditions.
- Staff Conduct – Investigating misconduct or abuse by correctional officers.
- Budget & Operations – Evaluating how taxpayer money is spent within the prison system.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

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COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION:			
WITNESS NAME: PRECIOUS JONES		PHONE NUMBER: 417-943-0757	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME: BREAKING GENERATIONAL POVERTY FOUNDATION		TITLE:	
ADDRESS: PO BOX 470306			
CITY: ST. LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63147
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:	SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM	
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MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: RASHEEDA MAXWELL		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: rmaxwell1200@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 11:25 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

Hello my name is Rasheeda Quarles I am in support for the bills HB-603 and also HB 774 and HB 729. We are in need of the support from the outside to take on issues that our family members are having inside of the walls of these prisons. Within these facilities there are family members working as the warden, assist warden and the wife of assist warden that are case managers to be able to reject the IR's that the inmates bring fourth for it just get dismissed without care. Thank you for listening and I ask that you please hear what we are speaking on and about.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: RASHEEDA QUARLES		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM
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MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: RAYMOND JAMES		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: raymondjames552@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 3/31/2025 12:31 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			
Without I oversight thins always go badly.			



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: REGINA MILLINER		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: reginamilliner@myyahoo.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 10:44 AM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

please vote YES on HB 774, HB 603, and HB 729. These bills would create independent prison oversight in Missouri. This is important because there is a lot of abuse, neglect, violence, understaffing, and lack of programming inside our state prisons. These poor conditions affect incarcerated people, correctional staff, and the families of both negatively. I encourage you to visit a prison and talk to both incarcerated people and staff, and VOTE YES on HB 774, HB 603, and HB 729.
Regina Milliner



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: ROSALYN JACKSON		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: burchettbey@aol.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 12:08 PM
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			

My name is Rosalyn Jackson. I live in St. Louis City, O'Fallon community. As a parent who had an incarcerated son, as a friend to many other parents who did and still do, and as an affiliate of Mothers of Incarcerated Sons and Daughters, (MISD); I've found it imperative to be able to know that my son and all of the other families' relatives were being treated fairly in spite of their criminal status. There must be oversight from outside parties/entities whose interest is to make the process of transitioning back into society as smooth as possible. When inmates are abused inside of prisons and do not receive the mental support and other medical attention they need, they return to their communities often worse than when they began serving time. We must protect them and those who are employed to ensure their time incarcerated is beneficial for all (and not just profit for the penal businesses). Thank you!



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
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COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
REGISTERED LOBBYIST:			
WITNESS NAME: SAGE CORAM		PHONE NUMBER:	
REPRESENTING: AMERICAN CIVIL LIBERTIES UNION OF MISSOURI		TITLE:	
ADDRESS: 906 OLIVE #1130			
CITY: ST. LOUIS		STATE: MO	ZIP: 63101
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:	SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM	
THE INFORMATION ON THIS FORM IS PUBLIC RECORD UNDER CHAPTER 610, RSMo.			



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
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TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: SARAH FELTS		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: sarah.felts@gmail.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 4:48 PM
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MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: SHARON TURLINGTON		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: sharonturlington@att.net	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 10:18 AM

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Please pass prison oversight to save taxpayerMoney, improve conditions dr residents and staff.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

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COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: STEVEN SOLOMON		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: stevesol@hey.com	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 3/31/2025 1:40 PM

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Oversight for Missouri Department of Corrections – accountability measures are needed to address systemic health and safety conditions in Missouri’s prisons.



MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

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COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: TABITHA VELTROP		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM
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MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
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BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☒ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☐ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: TAMMY REED		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM
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BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: ARNIE C. AC "HONEST-ABE" DIENOFF		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL:	ATTENDANCE:		SUBMIT DATE: 4/2/2025 12:00 AM
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MISSOURI HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES
WITNESS APPEARANCE FORM

BILL NUMBER: HB 729		DATE: 4/2/2025	
COMMITTEE: Corrections and Public Institutions			
TESTIFYING: ☐ IN SUPPORT OF ☐ IN OPPOSITION TO ☒ FOR INFORMATIONAL PURPOSES			
WITNESS NAME			
INDIVIDUAL:			
WITNESS NAME: KENYA BRUMFIELD-YOUNG		PHONE NUMBER:	
BUSINESS/ORGANIZATION NAME:		TITLE:	
ADDRESS:			
CITY:		STATE:	ZIP:
EMAIL: Kenya.BrumfieldYoung@slu.edu	ATTENDANCE: Written		SUBMIT DATE: 4/1/2025 8:21 AM
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Chairperson and members of the committee, Thank you for the opportunity to provide testimony in support of House Bill 729, which would establish the Office of the Department of Corrections Ombudsman and create a Corrections Oversight Committee. I offer this testimony as a scholar and practitioner in criminal justice who has studied the systemic issues present in correctional environments and the documented benefits of independent oversight. National data clearly demonstrate the need for independent oversight in correctional facilities. According to the Bureau of Justice Statistics, in 2021 alone, nearly 58,000 formal grievances were filed by incarcerated individuals in state and federal prisons. Research by the Vera Institute of Justice shows that incarcerated individuals often hesitate to report abuse or violations through internal channels due to fear of retaliation or lack of follow-through. Independent ombudsman offices have been shown to increase trust, decrease violence, and improve institutional transparency. A 2020 report by the U.S. Commission on Civil Rights found that facilities with independent oversight bodies were more likely to correct rights violations, improve conditions, and demonstrate reductions in excessive use-of-force incidents. In particular, jurisdictions that implemented ombudsman offices saw a measurable decrease in litigation costs and grievances, resulting in financial savings and more efficient resolution of internal issues. Within Missouri, reports by the Department of Corrections and independent watchdogs like the ACLU of Missouri have highlighted chronic concerns regarding medical neglect, use of solitary confinement, sexual misconduct by staff, and barriers to family contact. In 2020, the Department paid over 7 million dollars to settle claims related to workplace harassment, retaliation, and abuse. A portion of these claims stemmed from issues raised by incarcerated individuals or whistleblowing staff. These concerns are not limited to isolated cases. In 2018, Missouri was ranked eighth highest in the nation for prison suicide rates. This raises serious questions about mental health care access, monitoring practices, and facility conditions. Oversight mechanisms like those proposed in HB 729 would create an infrastructure to detect and respond to such systemic issues before they escalate into crises. The benefits of ombudsman offices are well documented. The Washington State Office of the Corrections Ombuds, established in 2018, has reviewed over 4,000 constituent complaints and resolved hundreds of complex cases without the need for litigation. Annual reporting has led to procedural reforms related to health care, visitation, and grievance handling. Empirical studies published in peer-reviewed journals such as the Journal of Offender Rehabilitation show that transparency and accountability mechanisms, especially those involving external review, are associated with higher staff morale, reduced inmate misconduct, and lower turnover among correctional officers. These improvements are especially relevant for Missouri, which has experienced chronic staffing shortages in its correctional facilities. HB 729 provides a cost-effective and evidence-based solution to persistent oversight gaps in Missouri's correctional system. It establishes a framework for independent monitoring, facilitates data collection and public reporting, and empowers stakeholders to file complaints without fear of retaliation. By

increasing transparency and accountability, the state protects the rights and dignity of incarcerated individuals while also reducing long-term costs, litigation risk, and public distrust. I urge the committee to advance HB 729 and strengthen the integrity of correctional oversight in Missouri. Thank you for your time and your commitment to justice. This testimony reflects my personal views and expertise. It does not represent the views of Saint Louis University, its Board of Trustees, faculty, staff, donors, their descendants, or any other individuals or entities affiliated with the university in any capacity. Professor Kenya Brumfield-Young, MLS, MSCJ